



**MULAYAM WITH SON
AKHILESH (LEFT);
MAYAWATI**

From Strength to Strength

BSP	SP	BJP	CONG	RLD	OTHERS	VACANT	TOTAL
227	87	48	20	10	10	01	403

BSP had won 206 seats in 2007 Assembly polls.

Winners and Forfeitters

Of the 11 seats that went to bypolls, the SP held five, all of which have been won by the BSP. The BSP won nine seats in total. Two seats held by the Congress went to the BSP.

The BJP surrendered both seats it held, losing Lucknow (West) to the Congress and Kholasala to an Independent. It is for the first time in 24 years that the Congress has won Lucknow (West).

Akhilesh Yadav had won the Firozabad Lok Sabha seat in May but wife Dimple lost to the Congress's Raj Babbar by over 85,000 votes.

after 1978 that that a member of the Nehru-Gandhi dynasty had hit the trail for a candidate outside the family in a by-election. Thirty-one years ago, Indira Gandhi had campaigned for Mohsina Kidwai in Azamgarh.

However, Rahul could not ensure a win for the Issauli seat in Sultanpur, which borders his parliamentary constituency of Amethi. Though the SP had won Issauli in 2007, this time the BSP captured the constituency, pushing Congress candidate J.N. Tiwari to

second position. On the other hand, the Congress regaining the Lucknow (West) Assembly seat was the result of the charisma of PCC chief Rita Bahuguna-Joshi and her untiring campaign, though not without a big question mark. In the May Lok Sabha elections, BJP leader Lalji Tandon won from Lucknow, defeating Bahuguna-Joshi. He then resigned from the Assembly, causing the bypoll. Tandon was openly opposed to Amit Puri as he wanted his son Ashutosh Tandon alias

Gopalji to fill the Lucknow (West) vacancy. Puri, a known grassroots leader, lost by a slender margin of 2,100 votes. Sources say that Tandon, in a bid to defeat the BJP's official candidate, 'negotiated' with the Congress and allegedly asked his supporters to vote for the Congress.

However, Bahuguna-Joshi says the Congress victory in Lucknow (West) was an outright rejection of the BSP's agenda of destroying the Opposition with the help of the official machinery. The victory in Firozabad and Lucknow prefaced the success of Rahul Gandhi's 'Mission 2012', she claimed. Congress leader Pramod Tiwari believes that the results clearly indicate that in the coming elections, it would be BSP versus the Congress.

Mayawati has been quick to agree with the Congress that the SP lost five of its sitting Assembly seats and Firozabad because of its 'negativism' and its attempts to resort to naked 'dynastic politics'. At the same time she saw the triumph of her "Sarvajan Hiyaya, Sarvajan Sukhaya" (welfare to all sections) policy and rigorous implementation of development projects in the state during her two-and-a-half-year rule. But on the flip-side, this endorses the fact that her influence is still confined to Uttar Pradesh. In the just-concluded Maharashtra Assembly elections, 252 of the BSP's 282 candidates had lost their security deposits.

The BJP, which failed to win even a single seat in the last two rounds of the by-elections, has already been sidelined in Uttar Pradesh, once considered the "Hindutva heartland". The association of its former leader Kalyan Singh, the "Hindu Hriday Samrat" of Ayodhya, with Mulayam has caused anger among Muslims and socialists. Influential Muslim leaders took flight and roosted with either the BSP or the Congress when Kalyan joined hands with Mulayam. Mulayam didn't seem worried and battled on, banking heavily on the